

How do these invitations work?

Our research teams start identifying and working on what a potential customer is looking for before we actually send out invites to that customer. Within business units like 5G, IoT, and Vision we make roadmaps that are intended to keep us at least five years ahead of time.

We don't create just marketing research documents, we create IPs that are looked upon by big brands as futuristic technologies. If you are able to understand what a brand wants in advance, you can easily create an invitation that they will not say no to.

These invitations are general meetups and not big events. We prefer one-to-one invitations because that helps us keep up with the confidentiality levels required by our customers. Most of these meetings are scheduled at our facilities because that is how we can show our customers what we are capable of doing.

Then there is an experience room where customers can get to see most of the products and solutions we have worked on in the past. I think that also helps customers to be confident about us. In short, we prefer physical meets over phone calls with our customers.

Do you also participate in events?

Yes, we have been participating in a lot of events, and we are also a part of various organisations run by the government of India. VVDN actively participates in various panel discussions and seminars conducted by these organisations.

India vs global revenue, what's it like? Is there any change in strategy for acquiring global clients?

Presently, India contributes around 40 percent of our revenue whereas the rest 60 percent is from other countries. However, the India growth, owing to Make in India, is high at the moment. The growth in India, and outside India, is increasing at a phenomenal rate.

There is a slight change in strategy for international markets. Costs as well as the product sets for India and for international markets are different. We also see a difference between the Indian and international customers from a mindset perspective. We have hired local teams in countries like the USA and South Korea, and that has made our tuning work for all the regions of the world.

In one sentence, Indian customers are always going to compare you with products coming from countries like Taiwan and China. At VVDN we have learned to create products which meet the cost criteria of customers.

How did you create a local ecosystem when others have been struggling to do so for decades?

Let me be honest and give a lot of credit to what the government of the country has done in the last five years. We have seen a huge growth not just from a manufacturing perspective but also from the business perspective during the last five to seven years. We have had customers who are more willing to do local R&D and manufacturing in India.

To be very frank, it is just the mindset that one needs to establish an ecosystem. Once you have the mindset you will automatically find ways to make that happen. Today, when we meet different government departments like NITI Ayog or MeitY, I find that they are equally interested to take the manufacturing capabilities of India to the next level. I do not see any lack of intention.

Why we were able to do so was because we depended on ourselves from the very beginning. We were able to identify which products or categories would be the best to start with in order to build a local ecosystem. Applying for PLI schemes was never a strategy for us but bringing the right products and right customers to India was always on our mind.

We never got influenced by short-term factors and focused on the long term, and hence made the right investments. Now, automatically, we have not only become eligible for government schemes but also for unstoppable growth. How much you are dependent on others and how you can reduce that dependency is the key to growth. Rather than focusing on extracting benefits from government schemes, one should focus on building your capabilities first.

What has enabled you to compete against global ODMs?

It all starts with our deep product engineering capabilities. Brands look at us as a single window to get their problems solved and products manufactured. They do not have to go to different places to get different parts of a product done.

Second is creating facilities where infrastructure to develop products are all under one roof. In terms of shipping time, we are today competing with ODMs from China, Taiwan, and the USA.

Could you elaborate on your collaboration with universities?

We have a concept of hiring people

when they are in their third or fourth year. We hire them well in advance and bring them to our core offices for R&D. I believe that R&D does not have space for pressure. The lesser the pressure, the better the innovation and the product gets.

We hire people before they even complete their studies. Similarly, we also support PhD students who work for at least one or two years with us before they have completed their studies. This is only possible when you go to them, as travelling for students is difficult. Hence, we are establishing R&D labs inside universities. Students from these and nearby universities are given access to such labs.

By the time they complete their studies, they get acclimatised with how we work and our product engineering culture. This has helped us file more IPs. There is mutual benefit for us as well as the universities.

How does collaboration with silicon companies help?

Our relations with silicon companies are quite unique. As we buy silicon from them, we are customers for them. This relationship gets extended in the form of R&D work we do with these silicon companies in terms of hardware and software. We get access to solutions that haven't even entered mass manufacturing stages. That way our team gets familiar with silicon that is yet to be launched in the market.

The use-cases found in the process are taken to our customers by our teams and, as I said earlier, this is one more step which helps us keep ahead of the time. Customers benefit because they know where the market is headed and what products they might need. In short, we complete the loop between companies, technologies, and products that they will need.

What's the plan ahead?

We have applied for multiple PLIs on offer by the government of India. I think we have just touched the tip of the ice. The customers have started looking at India as a blue-eyed country. We want to make sure that we create an infrastructure that enables us to grab these opportunities—whether it is electronics assembly lines, or mechanical facilities like moulding and injection, or R&D labs. VVDN is committed towards its goal of being a premier product engineering and manufacturing company in India dedicated to creating opportunities and transforming lives. **EFY**